集装箱：重塑世界的铁盒子

The Steel Box That Remade the World



一个普通铁箱，怎样改变了全球货运？

英文原文

On 26 April 1956 a converted Second World War tanker, the Ideal X, slipped out of Port Newark, New Jersey, for Houston. Clamped to her deck were 58 containers, trailer bodies detached from their wheels and chassis. Few spectators would have taken so unremarkable a cargo for a landmark.

At the time, freight travelled loose. Gangs of twenty or more dockworkers carried sacks, barrels, and crates piece by piece. It was strenuous drudgery. Ships could spend up to half their time berthed, and theft was rampant. In 1956 loading loose cargo cost about $5.83 a ton; loading the Ideal X cost, by the company's reckoning, about 16 cents.

Containers were not new. The hurdle was consensus: rival firms' boxes had incompatible dimensions and latches. An international standards committee formed in 1961. In January 1963 Sea-Land, the Ideal X's renamed operator, let the committee use its patents free of royalties, including those on corner fittings for hoisting. Lifted by crane, a box could be transferred smoothly between ship, lorry, and train.

This efficiency came at the expense of livelihoods. New York's waterfront employment shrank by about three quarters between 1963 and 1976. Much of the cargo crossed the harbour to a new terminal at Elizabeth, inaugurated in August 1962. Most of London's historic docks closed one after another from 1967 to 1980, while Felixstowe, on the Suffolk coast, expanded.

The rewards were substantial. A study published in the Journal of International Economics in 2016 estimated that containerisation had lifted trade between industrialised countries by a cumulative 700 per cent over 20 years. Tireless cranes now lift identical containers into orderly, immense stacks.

中文译文

1956年4月26日，一艘由二战油轮改装而成的“理想X号”悄然驶出新泽西州纽瓦克港，前往休斯敦。甲板上固定着58个集装箱：它们原是挂车车厢，已从车轮和底盘上拆下。几乎没有旁观者会想到，这批平淡无奇的货物将成为一个里程碑。

当时，货物都是散装运输。每组二十人或更多的码头工人，一件件搬运麻袋、木桶和板条箱。这是繁重而枯燥的苦差事。船舶多达一半的时间可能耗在泊港上，偷窃也十分猖獗。1956年，装载散货每吨约需5.83美元；而据运营公司估算，“理想X号”的装船费用每吨仅约16美分。

集装箱并非新事物，障碍在于达成共识：竞争公司的箱子尺寸与锁扣互不兼容。1961年，一个国际标准委员会成立。1963年1月，“理想X号”的运营方——当时已更名为海陆公司——允许委员会免付专利使用费，使用其专利，其中包括用于吊装的角配件专利。吊机把箱子吊起后，便能在船舶、卡车和火车之间顺畅转运。

这种效率提升也以人们的生计为代价。1963至1976年，纽约滨水区的就业人数缩减了约四分之三。大量货运转移到港湾对面的伊丽莎白新码头；该码头于1962年8月启用。1967至1980年，伦敦大多数历史悠久的码头相继关闭，萨福克海岸的费利克斯托港却不断扩张。

回报同样可观。2016年发表于《国际经济学杂志》的一项研究估计，集装箱化在20年间使工业化国家间的贸易累计增长了约700%。如今，不知疲倦的吊机把规格一致的集装箱吊起，码成整齐而庞大的箱垛。

核心词汇

先记这22项。连着下方的原文短语一起回想。

cargo n.
船运货物
so unremarkable a cargo

landmark n.
里程碑；重大转折
a cargo for a landmark

freight n.
货物；货运
freight travelled loose

drudgery n.
单调繁重的苦差事
strenuous drudgery

rampant adj.
猖獗的；泛滥的
theft was rampant

reckoning n.
估算
by the company's reckoning

hurdle n.
障碍；难关
The hurdle was consensus

consensus n.
共识
The hurdle was consensus

incompatible adj.
互不兼容的
incompatible dimensions and latches

dimension n.
尺寸
incompatible dimensions and latches

patent n.
专利
use its patents free of royalties

royalty n.
专利使用费
use its patents free of royalties

crane n.
起重机；吊机
Lifted by crane

transfer v.
转运；转移
could be transferred smoothly

efficiency n.
效率
This efficiency came

at the expense of 介词短语
以……为代价
at the expense of livelihoods

livelihood n.
生计
at the expense of livelihoods

employment n.
就业；就业人数
waterfront employment shrank

inaugurate v.
正式启用
inaugurated in August 1962

substantial adj.
可观的；大量的
The rewards were substantial

cumulative adj.
累计的
a cumulative 700 per cent

identical adj.
完全相同的
lift identical containers

文中词汇与搭配

补充词汇共43项。保留每个表达在本文中的意思。

convert v.
改装；改造

tanker n.
油轮

slip out of 动词短语
悄然驶离

clamp v.
夹紧；固定

container n.
集装箱

trailer n.
挂车

detach from 动词短语
从……拆下

wheel n.
车轮

chassis n.
车辆底盘

spectator n.
旁观者

unremarkable adj.
平淡无奇的

loose adj.
散装的；未捆装的

gang n.
一组工人

dockworker n.
码头工人

sack n.
大袋；麻袋

barrel n.
大桶

crate n.
板条箱

strenuous adj.
繁重费力的

up to 介词短语
多达

berth v.
停泊；靠泊

theft n.
偷窃

load v.
装载

文中词汇与搭配 续

补充词汇共43项。保留每个表达在本文中的意思。

by prep.
据；按照

rival adj.
竞争对手的

latch n.
锁扣；门闩

international standard 名词短语
国际标准

fitting n.
配件

hoist v.
吊起；吊装

smoothly adv.
顺畅地

lorry n.
卡车

waterfront n.
滨水区

shrink v.
缩减

terminal n.
货运码头

historic adj.
历史悠久的

dock n.
码头

expand v.
扩张

reward n.
回报

economics n.
经济学

industrialised adj.
工业化的

tireless adj.
不知疲倦的

orderly adj.
整齐有序的

immense adj.
巨大的

stack n.
垛；整齐堆叠的一摞

回想与回顾

先遮住下方答案，再把四个词放回原文。

01 The hurdle was _____:

02 and theft was _____.

03 rival firms' boxes had _____ dimensions and latches.

04 This efficiency came at the expense of _____.

文章主线

- 启航 过去码头逐件搬散货，船常久停；1956年，理想X号载58个集装箱启航。
- 降本 据运营方估算，该船每吨装船费约0.16美元，远低于当时散货的5.83美元。
- 互通 各家箱型原不兼容；运营方海陆公司免费开放专利，推动标准统一，箱子可在船、卡车和火车间转运。
- 转移 货运转向新港，老码头和工人生计受冲击；1963至1976年，纽约滨水区就业缩减约四分之三。
- 回报 2016年一项研究估计，集装箱化在20年间使工业化国家间贸易累计增加约700%。

参考答案　1 consensus 2 rampant 3 incompatible 4 livelihoods